

How Small Businesses Manage Stock Right Now

Products, services & methods in use — with a UK independent high-street lean

Deep-research report • Prepared for Alex Sisson, S-Move • 5 July 2026

Method: 102 research agents • 20 sources fetched • 25 claims adversarially verified (14 confirmed, 11 rejected)

The short version

Stock management sits on a **spectrum of effort and cost**. At the bottom, shops use memory, pen-and-paper, or spreadsheets — cheap but error-prone. In the middle, **payment-first POS apps** (Square, Zettle) bolt light stock tracking onto a card reader for free. At the top, **full EPOS systems** (Lightspeed, Epos Now, Shopify POS) bake real-time inventory directly into the till.

The universal trade-off for independents: **the cheap tools barely track stock, and the tools that track stock properly cost more and do more than a small shop needs.**

The landscape, tier by tier

1. Manual & spreadsheets (the floor)

Memory, paper, and Excel/Google Sheets remain the default for the smallest shops. Sources consistently cite the breakdown point at roughly **200–500 active SKUs** — beyond that, manual-entry errors compound, version drift sets in (duplicate files, stale data), and stock levels stop reflecting reality. It works for a single stock-keeper with a small catalogue; it fails quietly as you grow.

■ **Honesty caveat:** every hard statistic on *how many* small businesses use manual/spreadsheet methods (the widely-quoted “43% track manually or not at all”, “58% use non-dedicated methods”) was **refuted during verification** — they trace to marketing blogs citing each other, not primary data. These methods are real and common, but there is no trustworthy percentage.

2. Payment-first POS (the low-barrier entry) — confirmed

The cheapest real entry point. Free till software, you only pay per transaction, and the reader is cheap.

Tool	Software	Card rate	Reader	Contract
Zettle / PayPal POS (rebranded 2026)	Free	1.75% in-person	from £29+VAT	None
Square	Free plan (basic multi-store)	1.75% in-person	£19+VAT	None; Plus £49/mo at 1.6%

Suits **single-store shops, pop-ups, market and mobile traders**. The catch: inventory depth is minimal, and Square gates proper cross-location stock sync behind its paid Plus/Premium tiers.

3. Unified commerce — Shopify POS — confirmed

For shops that already sell (or want to sell) online. **One stock pool for web + counter** — inventory updates the moment a sale happens, either channel. UK entry is ~£25/mo plus a £49 reader; POS Lite is free with any Shopify web plan. But full inventory ops (purchase orders, low-stock alerts) need **POS Pro** at

+£69/mo per location. Only makes sense if you're a Shopify user.

4. Full retail EPOS — Lightspeed & Vend — confirmed

The deep end. **Lightspeed Retail** builds inventory into the till: matrix SKUs (size/colour variants), serial tracking, purchase orders, supplier catalogues, multi-location — every sale and return updates stock instantly across all stores and channels. **Vend is now Lightspeed** (acquired ~\$350M, 2021); it's the tablet version that auto-generates a reorder request when stock hits a minimum level (you approve it, it doesn't auto-order).

UK pricing **~£75 Basic / £149 Core / £189 Plus per month.** Two important flags:

- Reviews repeatedly say it's **“more than many small shops need”** — expensive and complex.
- It now **strongly pushes merchants onto its own Lightspeed Payments** and fee-penalises third-party card machines — a growing lock-in pattern across the industry.

The pricing map — confirmed

- **£0–£50/mo** — basic (Square, Zettle, transaction-fee-only)
- **£50–£150/mo** — mid-tier (Epos Now ~£54, Shopify POS Pro ~£69)
- **£100–£300/mo** — multi-store / enterprise (Lightspeed £75–£289)

Most-used UK providers overall: Square, SumUp, PayPal POS (Zettle), Shopify POS, Lightspeed, Epos Now, Clover, Worldpay — with Lightspeed and Epos Now pitched specifically at stock-heavy independent retail.

Also surfaced but not fully price-verified: **Sortly** — mobile-first light inventory app, free tier + ~\$24/\$149 paid — which shops “outgrow as complexity increases.” **SumUp** is a major UK player but its specific pricing claims failed verification, so figures are omitted.

The pain points that remain

- **No real-time truth** — manual tracking means stock levels lag reality; reconciliation happens monthly and by hand.
- **Human-error compounding** — small entry mistakes snowball as SKU count rises.
- **Fragmentation** — separate, non-integrated systems for inventory, sales and purchasing that don't talk to each other.
- **Payment lock-in** — increasingly the software is a wedge to capture your card processing.

Why this matters for the Dealer app

This lands squarely on the QR stock-sync thesis. The research validates the gap: **the affordable tools independents actually use (Square/Zettle) barely track stock, and nothing in this landscape treats “one physical item = one online listing, don't double-sell it” as the core problem.** Everyone here is a *till that also counts stock*. A QR “stock-truth, not a till” framing is a genuinely different angle — it doesn't compete with EPOS on features, it solves the one-off-item double-selling problem a counting-based system inherently can't.

Two things worth folding in:

- **The 200–500 SKU cliff** is a natural wedge — exactly where a shop feels the pain but isn't ready for £150/mo Lightspeed.

- **Payment lock-in fatigue** is a real, growing grievance. A subscription-only, no-commission, doesn't-touch-their-payments model is the opposite of where incumbents are heading — a positioning asset, not just a compliance choice.

Confidence note: the tooling landscape, pricing, and how each system works are all solidly confirmed against vendor pages. The weak spot is quantifying manual/spreadsheet usage — treat any “X% of shops do Y” claim with suspicion until backed by a primary survey (e.g. an ONS or trade-body figure).

Key sources

- Lightspeed Retail — Inventory Management (vendor, primary): lightspeedhq.com/pos/retail/inventory-management-software
- Zettle by PayPal — Pricing (vendor): zettle.com/gb/pricing
- Square UK — Retail POS Pricing & Hardware (vendor): squareup.com/gb
- Shopify — POS Pricing (vendor): shopify.com/pos/pricing
- Lightspeed UK — Retail Pricing (vendor): lightspeedhq.com/uk/pos/retail/pricing
- Compare Your Business Costs — Retail EPOS systems (comparison)
- Expert Market — Cheapest Retail EPOS Systems UK (comparison)
- Business Expert — Best EPOS Systems for UK Businesses 2026 (comparison)
- Merchant Machine — Vend / Lightspeed review (comparison)
- Tech.co — Lightspeed vs Shopify POS (comparison)